

IN CONTEXT

Revolution in Europe

The Schumann family lived through a period of great political turmoil. The upheavals of the French Revolution in 1789 and the Industrial Revolution in Europe and the US (1760–c. 1840) gave rise, in 1848–1849, to a series of revolts across Europe sparked by mass social and economic discontent, and targeted at monarchical rule.

Revolutionary action began in Sicily and extended to France, Germany, Italy, and the Austrian Empire. The 1848 uprising in France was the only one to succeed and led to the downfall of the monarchy. The uprising in Dresden in May 1849 that Clara Schumann and her family became embroiled in was one of the last insurrectionary events of 1848–1849.



POPULAR UPRISING IN DRESDEN'S ALTMARKT, MAY 1849

Clara Wieck was born in Leipzig in 1819. Her mother was a singer and her father a music teacher. In 1824, when Clara was five, her parents divorced, after which she was brought up by her father. Recognizing her natural musical talent, he subjected his